

Cambodia Under Communism

Pol Pot and his regime sought to transform Cambodia, now called Democratic Kampuchea, in accordance with their radical ideology. Almost a quarter of Cambodia's population were brutally slaughtered in the name of progress and purification.

◀◀ BEFORE

Although the movement had existed for a long time—and had ideological roots in 1950s' Paris—the Khmer Rouge was born officially in 1968.

COMMUNIST GROWTH

With assistance, albeit inconsistent, from North Vietnam, Khmer Rouge guerrillas **launched an insurgency** against the Cambodian government. It remained relatively weak until 1970, when Lon Nol overthrew Prince Norodom Sihanouk and invited the US to **invade Cambodia** to wipe out North Vietnamese and Viet Cong sanctuaries. A **civil war escalated** between the Lon Nol government and the Khmer Rouge, causing the insurgency to grow.

Totally renouncing the modern “capitalist, imperialist” world represented by cities, Khmer Rouge leader Pol Pot dreamed of a communal, agrarian, communist society, inspired by an idyllic image of pre-modern Cambodian peasants. He declared 1975 “Year Zero” of the new order and the country was given a new name: Democratic Kampuchea.

Road to agrarianism

Pol Pot believed that to cleanse society, all people must return to the land. Untold numbers of people perished on long marches from urban areas to rural work camps. The so-called “new” people, the products of urban culture—intellectuals, professionals, the educated, and those with worldly possessions—were ferreted out and often executed, as were many non-Khmer minorities. Starvation, disease, and work exhaustion killed hundreds of thousands more.

Systematic genocide

Numerous prison camps and execution centers were set up in the countryside to hold and punish those considered enemies of the regime. The most infamous of these camps was Tuol Sleng prison—known as S-21—which was presided over by the notorious Comrade Duch, Kang Kek Iew. In such prison camps, interrogators employed heinous torture methods to gain confessions from supposed “traitors against the revolution,” many of whom were casualties of the internecine power struggles among the Khmer Rouge factions, or were accused of being Vietnamese sympathizers.

Of the 17,000 people who passed through Tuol Sleng, only a few—one source says seven—survived. The others were executed at nearby Choeung Ek, a former orchard that became known as the most infamous of “The Killing Fields.” Prisoners there were often hacked, beaten, or bludgeoned to death to save bullets.

Extensive research by the Yale University Cambodian Genocide Program and by the Cambodian Documentation Center estimates that total deaths in the country reached more than two million. Some claims suggest more than three million were killed under the Khmer Rouge regime. Mass graves have been identified to account for nearly 1.4 million individuals. Like the Nazis during World War II, the Khmer Rouge torturers kept meticulous records and thousands of pictures of their victims.